

Body Language and Public Speaking

A Guide to Improving Your Presentation Skills

Welcome to the World of Public Speaking!

This is a skill you will use throughout your life, and is not just something you do at school. It is an essential tool that will open doors to endless opportunities to you, both personally and professionally.

Whether you're preparing for a group presentation, joining the Debate Team or simply want to convince someone to accept a point of view you're passionate about, the skills and tips you learn here will help you get there!

Let's look at one of the most important aspects of Public Speaking you should master to engage and persuade your audience: body language.

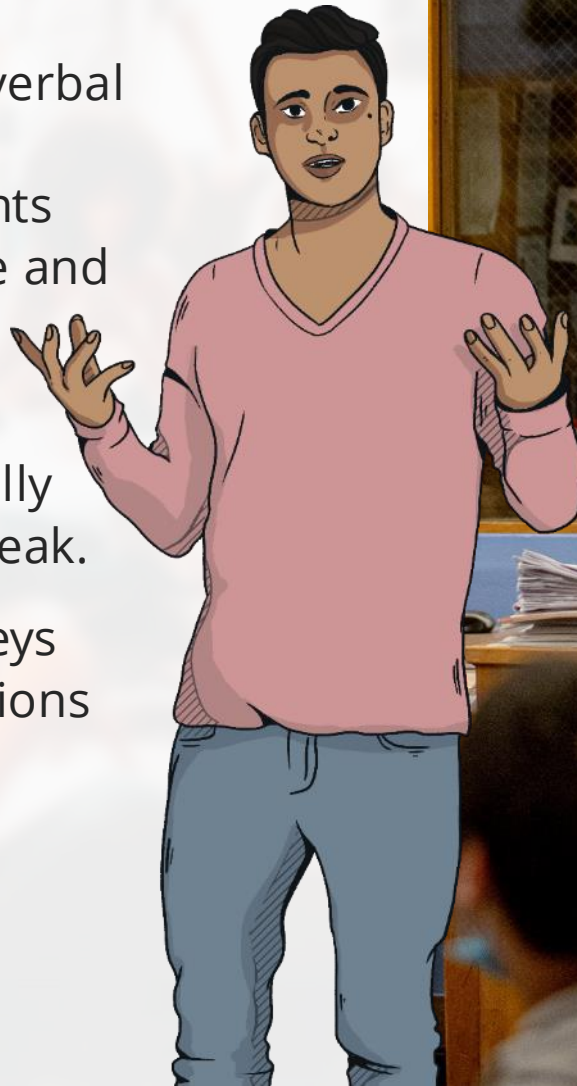


What is Body Language?

Body language is the non-verbal communication expressed through physical movements including gestures, posture and facial expressions.

It is a powerful form of communication as it typically enhances the words we speak.

Body language often conveys emotions, attitudes, intentions and sometimes, unspoken thoughts.



Think-Pair-Share!



On your worksheet, complete Question 1. Once complete, discuss your answers as a class.

Imagine you are observing the audience at a live comedy show. List THREE examples of body language you might see in an audience member at this time.

and

Imagine you are observing a person of importance giving a speech to the nation. List THREE examples of body language you might see in this person as they speak.



5 Key Elements of Body Language

When you think of body language, you might think of the phrase, “actions speak louder than words.”

Let’s take a close look at five key elements of body language to consider the next time you are presenting to a group.

1. Posture
2. Hand Gestures
3. Eye Contact
4. Facial Expressions
5. Proximity to Audience



1. Posture

This is very important when public speaking because it tells the audience how **confident** you are as a speaker. When you appear confident, the words you speak are likely to be seen as more **credible**.

Do: Stand tall and still with your chin up.

Don't: Fidget, rock back and forth on your feet or slouch.



Question 2

On your worksheet, complete Question 2. Once complete, discuss your answers as a class.

In your own words, explain why posture is important while giving a speech. Provide ONE example of where this would apply.



2. Hand Gestures

You don't want to be caught fidgeting or moving nervously while speaking, but you also don't want to lose your audience's interest by standing completely still.

Use hand gestures to **emphasise points**, maintain your audience's interest and reinforce your own confidence as a speaker.

Do: Use your fingers to count out key points, point where necessary and open your palms upwards to the audience.

Don't: Tap nervously on the podium/table, scratch your body, touch your face or put your hands on your hips.



Question 3

On your worksheet, complete Question 3. Once complete, discuss your answers as a class.

In your own words, explain how hand gestures can improve your presentation. Provide TWO specific examples.



3. Eye Contact

Eye contact **creates a connection** between you and the audience. It shows you care about what you say and how this information is being received. It also shows that you **value** your audience's interest and input.

Do: Hold eye contact with each audience member (where possible) for 3-5 seconds.

Don't: Flick your eyes around the room, stare at the ceiling/floor or rely on your notes throughout your presentation.



Questions 4 – 5

On your worksheet, complete Questions 4-5. Once complete, discuss your answers as a class.

Explain why eye contact is important when holding a conversation with one or two other people.

and

In your own words, explain how eye contact can improve the way your audience engages in your presentation. Give TWO examples.



4. Facial Expressions

Your **passion** for a topic should show through your facial expressions, whether enthusiastic, saddened, angry or enlightened.

Facial expressions also **engage** the audience (as a form of subtle entertainment) and can even build empathy between you and your audience.

Do: Smile and raise your eyebrows where necessary and effective.

Don't: Speak with a blank stare or mismatch your expressions to what you are saying (e.g. smile while talking about something upsetting, or frown while sharing a message of positivity).



Questions 6 – 7



On your worksheet, complete Questions 6-7. Once complete, discuss your answers as a class.

Write down TWO examples of facial expressions you might see used by a presenter at an actors' awards show. Explain why they are used and the effect they have on the audience.

and

Explore the possible facial expressions you might see used by a motivational speaker on the topic of overcoming hardship.



5. Proximity to Audience

Understanding the space you've been given allows you to:

- Control your voice projection according to the distance between you and your audience.
- Use your space effectively for pacing or moving closer to/further from the audience for effect as necessary.
- Improve your ability to engage and persuade.

Do: Move closer to your audience to build trust where appropriate.

Don't: Stand behind a podium for a long time unless this is required of the setting / is a marker of respect (e.g. A Principal's Address).



Also consider...

Voice Projection

Being in control of your voice volume is important as it ensures your audience hears what you are saying with clarity. It better captivates their attention and shows you are confident.

Do: When presenting in a large space, start by asking if the people at the back can hear you clearly. This is a great way to gauge your volume from the start.

Don't: Shout/bellow when presenting in a small room to few people, or speak softly in a large space (even if you are given a microphone).



and...

Articulate your Words and Slow your Speech

Taking the time to speak slowly and purposefully will make it easier for your audience to hear what you are saying, *and* **remember** the information you share.

Speaking too fast can make it difficult for the audience to retain information.

Do: Practise your speech ahead of time so you aren't rushing to beat the timer.

Don't: Assume your audience isn't interested in what you're saying! Your audience wants their time to be used **effectively**. This means slowing your speech and articulating words so the audience can take something away from your presentation at the end.



Questions 8

On your worksheet, complete Question 8. Once complete, discuss your answers as a class.

Write ONE paragraph exploring the different ways you could approach presenting to a small audience (e.g. your class) and a large auditorium of people (e.g. your school).

Be sure to talk about proximity to audience, voice projection and any other elements of public speaking you have learned that are relevant.



Think-Pair-Share!



On your worksheet, complete Question 9. Once complete, discuss your answers as a class.

In pairs, read through the following list of public speaking situations.

In the right-hand column, write up to four examples of body language (in bullet point form) the speaker should consider while presenting.

The first one has been done for you.



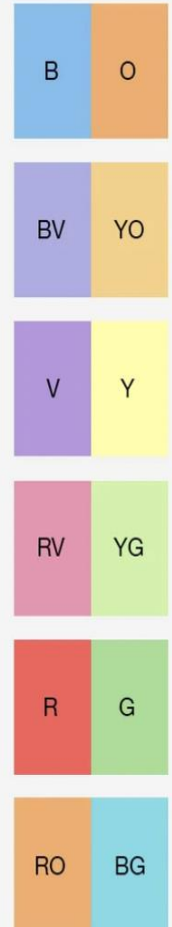
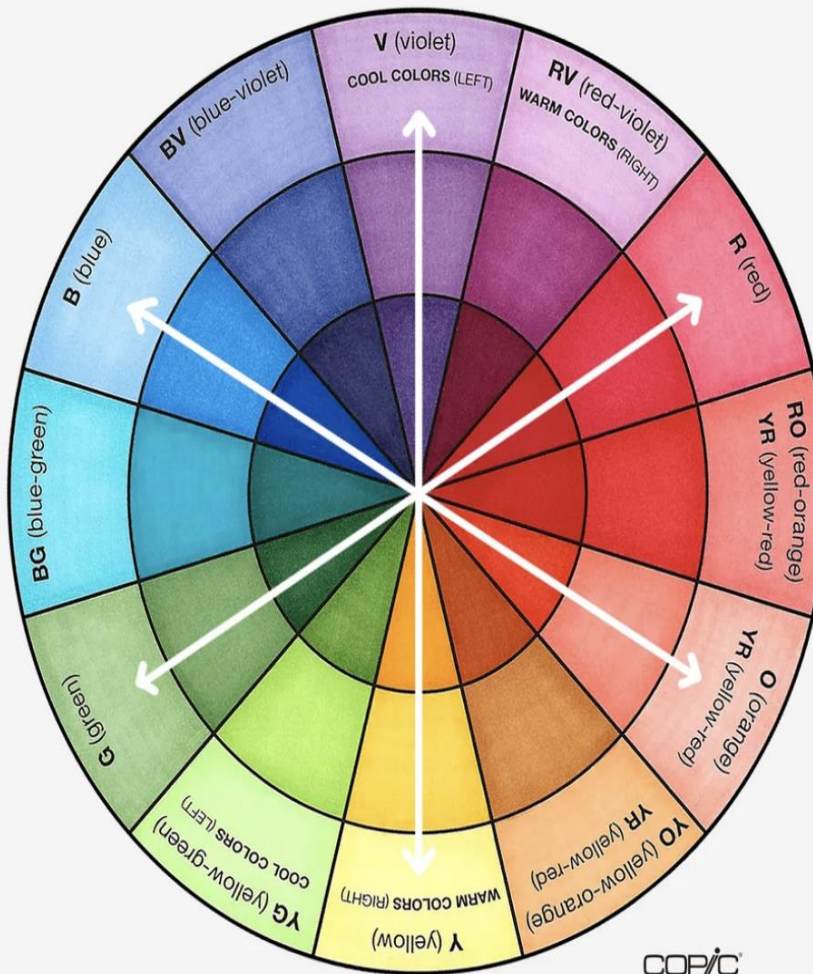
Top 10 Colour Schemes that Make Slides Memorable

Complementary

Complementary colors are directly across from each other on the color wheel.

These can be any two colors, but it's most commonly seen between primaries and secondaries. Below are some examples in reference to Copic markers.

Blue and Orange	(B14, YR15)
Blue-Violet and Yellow-Orange	(BV13, Y35)
Violet and Yellow	(V05, Y17)
Red-Violet and Yellow-Green	(RV06, YG07)
Red and Green	(R43, G12)
Red-Orange and Blue-Green	(R05, BG05)



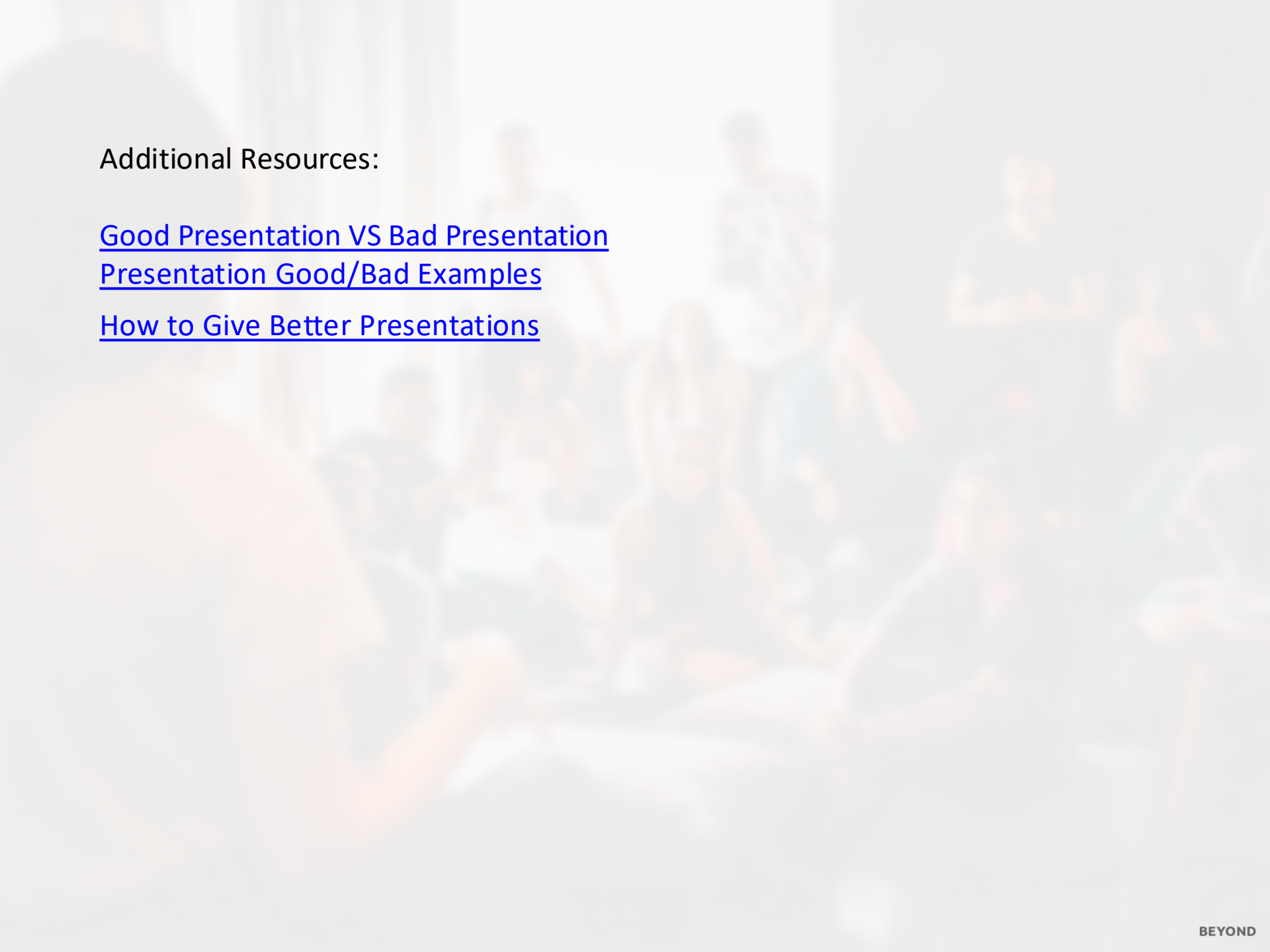
Pro Tips for Using Colour in Presentations

- **Limit to 3–4 main colours** to avoid visual chaos.
- **Use white or negative space** to let colours breathe.
- **Be consistent**—use the same colours for the same types of information.
- **Highlight selectively**—save your brightest or boldest colours for the most important elements.
- **Test on the actual display device** to make sure colours look as intended

Keeping these tips in mind, you will certainly improve your chances of persuading an audience with your knowledge, confidence and charisma in your next presentation.

Good Luck!





Additional Resources:

[Good Presentation VS Bad Presentation](#)

[Presentation Good/Bad Examples](#)

[How to Give Better Presentations](#)

